

card the products that once served us well but now are at the end of their lifecycle and no use to us.

The normal way of doing things involves calling the local kabadiwala or scrap dealer and giving off that old monitor, keyboard or washing machine that you no longer require. He in turn gives you some cash for it. We're not talking bundles of moolah here. It's usually the value of the metal used in the electronics by weight. You accept a few hundred rupees and forget about it. Ever wonder what happens to this e-waste once it's off your hands and out of your mind? There's more to this story than meets the eye. The waste changes a few hands and lands up at a scrapyards with lots of other discarded electronic goods. "That's not so bad", you might be thinking. But what happens to these goods after this point is the troubling bit. Gangs of unskilled, street urchins get down to work on these goods. They melt these components using methods that add smoke, toxins and alarmingly large amounts of greenhouse gasses to the environment. Not only that, the workers expose themselves to arsenic compounds that in many cases leave lasting damage. Shocking isn't it?

In a recent study published by the Associated Chambers of Commerce and Industry (ASSOCHAM) it revealed that just 4.5 percent of India's e-waste gets recycled. Furthermore India currently produces a staggering 4.4 lakh tons of e-waste annually! About 70 percent of this e-waste is computer equipment, telecom gadgets account for 12 percent and the rest includes, medical tools and household e-scrap. When such large quantities of goods are broken down using unskilled labour, non-standardised and unregulated extraction methods you can only imagine the kind of negative effect it has on the environment.

